The Battalion was deployed astride the Srinagar–Pattan–Baramulla and Srinagar–Narabal–Gulmarg roads. The Srinagar–Narabal stretch of the road was a very picturesque tree-lined avenue and its claim to fame was that the song '*Subhanallah Haseen Chehra*' from the film *Kashmir Ki Kali* had been shot here. The Companies were located at Company-operating bases (COB) at Khanpeth in the North, Dagerpura, on the banks of the Jhelum, Bemina, just on the outskirts of Srinagar, Soyibug (Dharmuna), Narabal and Malamu, the last two on the Narabal–Gulmarg Road, with the Bn HQ at the HMT. To the West of the main road was the Hokar Sar—a large wetland extending from North of the HQ all the way to Narabal and Soyibug, where migratory birds would come in the winters. The Hokar Sar was not very deep, but overgrown with reeds and rushes, ideal for ducks and other birds to hide in. During winters, the locals would often go poaching in its waters in their small flat-bottomed boats.

Soyibug was the ancestral village of Syed Salahuddin, the founder of the Hizbul Mujahideen (HM). He was in Pakistan, but the writ of the HM ran strong in this area, luring many youths to join the outfit. Soyibug was a 'Black' village, i.e., totally anti-government and pro-separatist. The Dharmuna COB was located bang in the middle of the village with the houses of the locals crowding it from three sides. Of all the COBs, this was the most vulnerable. The locals, egged on by the terrorists, would often pelt stones on the post from the cover of these houses or carry out stand-off firing from the fields on the open side. Even when inside the post, one could not relax and had to continuously wear protective gear, a bullet-proof jacket (BPJ) and a helmet at all times. The jawans had to have nerves of steel to not react to these provocations, which had the potential to cause serious collateral damage. During my term as the CO, the

Copyright @ Penguin Random House India
Not for circulation